Friday, 18 July 2008

'How can you claim that catch? You should be ashamed of yourself.'

Another Test, another day and another established cricketer is furious with me, and he's lambasting me over lunch.

Graeme speaks up on my behalf. 'Leave him alone and go away,' he says, as tempers begin to fray.

It's the first day of the second Test at Headingley in Leeds, and the usually calm England player is clearly livid with me because he thinks I claimed to have held a catch at second slip when, as far as he was concerned, I must have known the ball had touched the grass.

In truth, I simply didn't know whether or not the ball had carried. Everything happened in an instant and my first reaction was to ask Graeme, who was fielding at first slip, what he thought. He said it didn't matter because the umpire had referred the decision to his colleague watching on a screen in the stands.

So I stood there in the middle of the field, alongside everyone else – my teammates, batsmen, umpires and the crowd – watching the slow-motion replay on the giant screens; and the pictures showed the ball had bounced off my right hand and hit the ground before my left hand scooped it up.

Even before the 'NOT OUT' verdict appeared on the screen, an angry chorus of boos had started to rumble around the entire ground, each and every one of them directed at me. It was a difficult moment but, in all honesty, I had not known whether or not the ball had carried. I had only asked the question.

Over the salads at lunch, the England players are not letting the matter rest.

'That wasn't clever, young man,' says one senior England player as he passes our table.

A couple of my teammates bluntly tell him to move on.

After the high-scoring draw at Lord's, the series is catching fire in the